

UPSC Civil Services (Main) Simulation GS-II

DETAILED SOLUTIONS / ANSWER KEY | Time: 3 Hours | Maximum Marks: 250

Q1. Assess the role of the Objectives Resolution in the making of the Constitution.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (143 words; practice model, not official): The Objectives Resolution was the Assembly's value framework before the constitutional machinery was finalised. Nehru introduced it on 13 December 1946 and the Assembly adopted it on 22 January 1947. It located authority in the people, envisaged an independent sovereign republic, and committed the future order to justice, equality, freedom, safeguards for minorities and tribal or backward areas, territorial integrity and world peace. Its importance was institutional. Subject committees and the Drafting Committee could disagree about federal, executive or rights mechanisms, but they worked within a publicly declared normative horizon. Its modified form became the Preamble, giving continuity between nationalist constitutional aspiration and the enacted Constitution. The Resolution was not itself the final constitutional text: its language was modified, and later doctrine must be grounded in the Preamble and operative provisions. It was therefore the value bridge from political freedom to constitutional identity.

Q2. Distinguish government from governance and explain why the distinction changes the evaluation of a public institution in India.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (114 words; practice model, not official): Government names the institutions, governance names the process and good governance names the standard, so an evaluation that begins by identifying the duty-holder and the binding form reaches a defensible verdict while one that begins with adjectives about the state does not. Government is the formal, constitutionally mandated set of institutions - legislature, executive and judiciary - that holds legitimate public authority, and it is only one actor inside governance rather than the whole of it. Governance is the wider process by which state and non-state actors, including the market, civil society and citizens, together make, implement and enforce collective decisions, so a governance answer must name which actor holds the duty before it evaluates performance.

Q3. Distinguish distributive, corrective and recognitive justice, and show how the three-dimension test evaluates one Indian welfare intervention.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (111 words; practice model, not official): The three dimensions are distinct questions rather than synonyms, so analysis should define each by the question it asks, apply all three to one named Indian intervention, and close by showing that failure in any single dimension perpetuates the injustice. Corrective justice is concerned with remedying a specific wrong and asks the question how the harm is undone, and it is implemented through compensation, rehabilitation, penalty and restoration; it is the dimension that gives protective legislation its analytical shape, because a prohibition without a remedy, a penalty without enforcement capacity, or a rehabilitation entitlement without an alternative livelihood leaves the corrective claim unsatisfied even where the distributive claim has been met.

Q4. Explain why neither Parliament nor the judiciary is sovereign in India.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (140 words; practice model, not official): India combines a powerful Parliament with judicial review, but legal supremacy belongs to the Constitution. Parliament legislates within distributed competence and may amend the Constitution under Article 368. Its laws remain subject to Fundamental Rights, federal limits and judicial review under Articles 13, 32 and 226. Kesavananda Bharati further prevents amendment from damaging the basic structure. Courts can invalidate unconstitutional action and develop binding doctrine, but they exercise jurisdiction conferred by the Constitution. Judicial independence is not policy sovereignty; reasoned adjudication must remain anchored in text, structure and precedent. The arrangement rejects both Westminster-style unlimited parliamentary sovereignty and an unlimited judicial government. Parliament retains democratic law-making and broad constituent capacity; courts protect constitutional boundaries and remedies. Each checks the other only through constitutionally assigned powers. Thus the Indian synthesis is constitutional supremacy enforced by institutions, not supremacy of either institution.

Q5. Distinguish the funding source, the legal vehicle and the implementing organisation in India's development industry, and explain why the distinction matters.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (110 words; practice model, not official): Separating the three layers is what allows an answer to say which actor sets the agenda, which one carries the disclosure duty and which one determines last-mile fidelity, and an answer that collapses them cannot locate the accountability failure it is being asked to evaluate. The development industry is the ecosystem of bilateral and multilateral donors, public charitable trusts, private foundations and family philanthropy, corporate social responsibility programmes and implementing non-governmental organisations that collectively fund and deliver development alongside the state, so the analytical first move is to separate the funding source from the legal vehicle from the last-mile implementer instead of collapsing all three into the single word charity.

Q6. Elucidate why measured poverty and measured hunger can move in different directions.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (112 words; practice model, not official): Different instruments measure different deprivations, so analysis should separate monetary poverty, multidimensional poverty and anthropometry, then separate availability, access, absorption and utilisation to locate where the divergence is produced. Income or calorie poverty, multidimensional poverty and anthropometry measure different deprivations, so falling monetary poverty can coexist with continuing hunger and undernutrition, and this divergence is the analytical core of the demand that asks about poverty and hunger moving apart alongside shrinking social expenditure; the answer route is to separate availability, access, absorption and utilisation, because availability failures are procurement problems, access failures are entitlement and portability problems, and absorption failures are health, sanitation and disease problems that no grain allocation can reach.

Q7. Explain the constitutional significance of enacting the Preamble after the rest of the Constitution.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (136 words; practice model, not official): The Constituent Assembly deliberately considered the Preamble after the substantive Constitution so that the declaration would conform to the text already accepted. This completed a chain beginning with Nehru's Objectives Resolution, moved on 13 December 1946 and adopted on 22 January 1947, and ending in constitutional adoption on 26 November 1949. The sequence has two consequences. First, the Preamble is not a detached aspiration; it is a retrospective compression of the enacted distribution of authority, institutions and values. Second, that fit strengthens its interpretive reliability. Berubari Union (1960) could call it a key to the minds of the makers, while Kesavananda Bharati (1973) could treat its basic elements as part of constitutional identity. The sequence does not make the Preamble independently enforceable. It converts constituent purpose into authoritative evidence for interpreting, but not replacing, operative provisions.

Q8. Explain how bonding, bridging and linking social capital advance women's empowerment through self-help groups in India.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (107 words; practice model, not official): The chain works only in sequence, because trust within the group creates the savings discipline, federation supplies negotiating scale and vertical linkage converts that scale into credit, market and scheme access, and it stalls wherever any single stage is missing or captured. Social capital is the networks, norms of reciprocity and trust that enable collective action, and Putnam's typology separates bonding capital as dense trust within a homogeneous group, bridging capital as connection across otherwise separate groups, and linking capital as the vertical connection between citizens and formal institutions such as banks and government departments, with each performing a different governance function and none substituting for another.

Q9. Analyse why a functioning primary health structure is a precondition for sustainable development.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (116 words; practice model, not official): Primary care is where prevention, early detection and continuity are produced, so analysis should show that hospital-led systems buy treatment without buying health, and must anchor the claim in named Indian primary-care institutions. available evidence indicates that the health mission, free drugs and diagnostics initiatives and the health-infrastructure mission strengthen systems while uneven State capacity and workforce vacancies limit outcomes, and that Union financing and standards depend on State delivery capacity because health is delivered by the States; the answer consequence is that a national financing announcement is a necessary but not sufficient condition, and that a graded verdict on any national health programme must be conditioned on the delivery capacity of the State in question.

Q10. Explain why OCI is not dual citizenship. Evaluate the logic of its principal rights and restrictions.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (135 words; practice model, not official): Thesis: OCI is a statutory foreign-national card status under Sections 7A-7D, not Indian citizenship. Evidence: The 2021 MHA notification describes an OCI cardholder as a foreign national holding a foreign

passport and grants a lifelong multiple-entry visa, limited parity in fees, NRI-equivalent access in specified education/property/professional fields and FRRO exemption. Section 7B withholds the vote, legislative membership, Presidency/Vice-Presidency, judgeship and Article 16 public-employment equality. Analysis: The design supports diaspora mobility, investment and cultural connection without creating competing political allegiance. The restrictions track the distinction between social-economic access and democratic authorship. Qualification: OCI is not secure against all change: rights depend on notification and registration can be cancelled under Section 7D with a hearing. Conclusion: OCI is calibrated external membership - deeper than an ordinary visa, but deliberately short of nationality and political membership.

Q11. "Cabinet dominance in India is a product of constitutional fusion amplified by party and procedural power." Discuss.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (211 words; practice model, not official): Articles 74-75 create a ministry drawn from Parliament and sustained by Lok Sabha confidence. This fusion enables coordination, but does not alone explain cabinet dominance. Party amplification: A governing majority controls House outcomes. The whip, backed where applicable by Tenth Schedule disqualification risk, prioritises party survival over independent legislative judgment. Procedural amplification: Government business occupies most agenda time. Guillotining grants compresses financial scrutiny. Delegated legislation, Article 123 ordinances and an overbroad Money Bill route can reduce prior or bicameral examination. PM control of appointments, information and coordination may further convert cabinet into prime-ministerial government. Evidence: PRS records 274 sitting days for the full-term 17th Lok Sabha and only 16% of Bills referred to committees. This indicates reduced opportunity, not that every enactment lacked scrutiny. The concentration is therefore reinforced by an information asymmetry: ministers command the administration and legislative timetable, while ordinary members depend on limited research time, committee access and disclosure. Correctives: Article 75(3), Question Hour, DRSCs, PAC-CAG scrutiny, opposition, bicameralism, courts and elections constrain the executive. Judicial review matters because India follows constitutional, not parliamentary, sovereignty. Thus, cabinet dominance is fusion plus disciplined majority plus control of procedure and information. It marginalises deliberation, not Parliament's constitutional capacity. More sittings, committee referral and narrower whip use are the remedy.

Q12. Examine how convergence and pre-legislative consultation can reduce the implementation gap in Indian public policy.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (202 words; practice model, not official): Consultation improves design realism at formulation and convergence removes clearance points at delivery, so the two correctives act at different stages and neither can substitute for the other or for functional devolution. Convergence is the deliberate alignment of multiple schemes and departments toward a common local outcome, and its analytical value is that it adds no new scheme but removes clearance points and duplicate targeting between existing ones at the district and panchayat level, which is why it improves outcomes without a proportional increase in outlay and why it fails wherever functional devolution is absent. The Pre-Legislative Consultation Policy of 2014 advises Union departments to publish draft legislation with an explanatory note and an ordinary minimum public comment window of about thirty days before introduction, and it is an executive policy rather than a statute whose comments are not binding, so publishing a draft is consultation compliance while incorporating feedback is consultation depth. A regulatory impact assessment is a structured ex-ante assessment of a proposed regulation's costs, benefits and alternatives before it is finalised, and it remains unevenly institutionalised across Indian ministries and regulators, so it must be cited as an emerging good-governance practice rather than as a uniformly binding legal requirement.

Q13. Critically examine the National Education Policy, 2020 against the fourth Sustainable Development Goal.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (140 words; practice model, not official): Alignment of objectives is not the contested question, so the critical examination must accept the stated alignment, test finance, teachers and State capacity, and separate what is statutory from what is policy. The National Education Policy, 2020 is a policy document and not a statute, and it restructures school education into a five plus three plus three plus four design covering the foundational stage for ages three to eight, the preparatory stage for ages eight to eleven, the middle stage for ages eleven to fourteen and the secondary stage for ages fourteen to eighteen, while emphasising foundational literacy and numeracy, mother-tongue instruction, multidisciplinary higher education, multiple entry and exit and vocational integration; because it is policy rather than statute, its extension of focus to early childhood care and education creates no statutory entitlement, and saying otherwise is a status error.

Q14. Examine hedging as India's operational method toward competing major powers, and state the conditions under which it becomes costly.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (213 words; practice model, not official): Hedging is the simultaneous deepening of several partnerships on separate issue tracks rather than equidistance, so the examination must define it against bandwagoning and balancing, use the dated 2025-26

sequence as the stress test, and qualify it with the autonomy-dependence trade-off and the sanctions-obligation distinction. Bandwagoning means aligning with the stronger power, balancing means aligning against it, and hedging means pursuing both engagement and risk-mitigation with more than one power simultaneously, so hedging is the opposite of avoidance and is best described in the owners as India's posture toward the United States-China dynamic; the decisive analytical line is that hedging is not equidistance or fence-sitting, because it involves deepening several partnerships, often deeply and asymmetrically, on separate issue tracks rather than declining to commit on any of them. An issue-based coalition such as the Quad, I2U2 or the G4 is formed around one specific shared interest without a mutual-defence treaty obligation, whereas an alliance carries binding collective-defence commitments, and available evidence indicates that India's minilateral engagements are consistently the former and not the latter; the trap this distinction defuses is the assumption that participation in a named grouping implies alliance membership, and the analytical framework reinforces it with the alliance-autonomy conflation gap, which corrects the description of a deepened partnership as bloc membership.

Q15. Account for the legal and political factors responsible for the reduced frequency of using Article 356 by the Union Governments since the mid-1990s.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (158 words; practice model, not official): The reduced frequency of Article 356 reflects the conversion of President's Rule from a broad political weapon into a reviewable exceptional remedy. Legally, S.R. Bommai (1994) made federalism a basic feature, subjected proclamation material to judicial review, preferred an Assembly floor test for disputed majority and permitted restoration after unconstitutional dismissal. Later floor-test decisions increased the legal and reputational cost of partisan action. Article 355's duty cannot itself prove the Article 356 threshold that government cannot be carried on according to the Constitution. Politically, coalition governments and strong regional parties increased State bargaining power. A competitive party system made arbitrary dismissal electorally costly, while media, opposition and judicial scrutiny strengthened accountability. Sarkaria and Punchhi recommendations reinforced the norm of warning, alternatives and last resort. Use has not disappeared because genuine constitutional breakdown can still occur. The decline is therefore best explained by judicial discipline interacting with plural party politics, not by repeal or desuetude of Article 356.

Q16. Examine the inadequacies that hamper effectiveness, transparency and accountability in e-governance and the correctives each requires.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (214 words; practice model, not official): The inadequacies are not primarily technological but an unreformed process, unreliable source data and an unnamed duty-holder, and digitisation makes each of these faster and more visible without making any of them better, so the correctives must be matched bucket by bucket rather than pooled into a plea for more technology. The inadequacies that hamper e-governance fall into three buckets that most answers merge - effectiveness inadequacies of unreformed back-end processes, poor source data, services initiated online but finished offline and weak interoperability that forces repeated document submission; transparency inadequacies of status visible without reasons, rules and eligibility not published in usable form and dashboards reporting disposal without recurrence or quality; and accountability inadequacies of no identifiable officer attached to a delay, escalation that closes tickets without resolving the underlying capability gap, no penalty outside notified right-to-service coverage and no independent validation of self-reported performance. The National e-Governance Service Delivery Assessment is administered by the Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances, and the NeSDA 2021 portal parameters are accessibility, content availability, ease of use, information security and privacy, end service delivery, integrated service delivery, and status and request tracking; the assessment must not be described as guaranteed biennial and its parameter list must not be inflated by merging every related assessment category into it.

Q17. Assess whether the Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace Act, 2013 has extended workplace safety beyond the organised sector.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (160 words; practice model, not official): Coverage was extended in law and only partly in delivery, so the assessment must set the Internal Committee threshold against the Local Committee route, use the inclusion of a dwelling place within workplace as the decisive test case and close on district capacity rather than on statutory intent. The Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal) Act, 2013 defines sexual harassment as unwelcome physical, verbal or non-verbal conduct of a sexual nature, and requires an employer to constitute an Internal Committee wherever employee strength is ten or more; available evidence indicates that a complaint is to be inquired into within ninety days, that non-compliance attracts penalties and that repeat default can lead to cancellation of licence or registration; they also record the recurring compliance failure that the required external member with experience of women's issues is often not appointed, which means the statutory design and the delivered committee are two different objects and must be argued separately.

Q18. Examine the implementation-credibility gap in India's neighbourhood connectivity and development commitments.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (142 words; practice model, not official): The gap is typically between a segment delivered and a corridor completed rather than between announcement and inaction, so the examination must date the Akhaura-Agartala link, the Kaladan waterway and port, the Sri Lanka memoranda and the Bhutan commitments, and close by naming the specific mechanism that stalled each one. The Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link was inaugurated on 1 November 2023, complementing restored rail, inland-waterway, road and power links, and the Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal Motor Vehicles Agreement was signed in 2015 to facilitate cross-border passenger and cargo movement; the owners attach a limitation to each, namely that customs, trans-shipment, domestic politics and last-mile infrastructure determine actual use of a rail link, and that Bhutan's non-ratification has constrained four-country implementation of the Motor Vehicles Agreement, so subregionalism progresses where SAARC-wide consensus is unavailable but does not by itself deliver seamless movement.

Q19. Cesses, surcharges and centrally sponsored schemes can re-centralise fiscal federalism even when tax devolution remains high. Analyse.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (206 words; practice model, not official): The Finance Commission may recommend a substantial State share, but effective fiscal autonomy depends on the base being shared and the conditions attached to other transfers. Article 270 distributes the divisible pool, while Article 271 permits Union-purpose surcharges whose proceeds are not shareable. Cesses are similarly commonly kept outside the divisible pool. Growth in these instruments can reduce the proportion of gross Union tax revenue subject to the stated devolution percentage. Centrally sponsored schemes support national priorities and equal citizenship, but detailed guidelines, matching contributions and fragmented funding may constrain State budgeting. States carry major responsibilities in health, agriculture, police and local services, so conditional transfers can convert them into implementation agencies. Counterarguments matter. Cesses can finance identifiable national externalities; schemes can reduce interstate inequality; and the 16th Finance Commission retains 41% rules-based vertical devolution. State capacity and accountability also justify performance conditions. The corrective is not abolition but transparency and consent: sunset clauses and reporting for cesses, a protected divisible-pool base, fewer and more flexible schemes, predictable Union shares, outcome-based rather than input-heavy conditions, and regular ISC/GST consultation. Thus, formal devolution and practical autonomy can diverge. Fiscal federalism must be evaluated through total transfer design, not the headline percentage alone. Answer-prose count: 202 words.

Q20. Examine the adequacy of India's current data-protection framework as a safeguard for its digital public infrastructure.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (163 words; practice model, not official): India built the rails before it commenced the safeguards, so the honest verdict is that the architecture is world-scale while the protection framework is enacted, notified and substantially not yet in force, and the assessment must be written with sections, tranches and dates rather than with adjectives. The Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 commences in three tranches under the notification G.S.R. 843(E) of 13 November 2025 - immediately, covering section 1(2), the section 2 definitions, sections 18 to 26 establishing the Board, sections 35 and 38 to 43, and section 44(1) and section 44(3); at twelve months on 13 November 2026, covering section 6(9) on consent managers and section 27(1)(d); and at eighteen months on 13 May 2027, covering sections 3 to 5, the remainder of section 6, sections 7 to 17 including Data Principal rights, sections 27 to 34 other than section 27(1)(d), sections 36 and 37 and section 44(2).

END OF DETAILED SOLUTIONS